

Boats and ships

The first powered vessels were little more than rowing boats fitted with steam engines and paddle wheels. Over time, the combination of steel hulls and powerful engines allowed all kinds of gigantic ships to be created—from vast supertankers to liners carrying thousands of passengers.

FAST FACTS

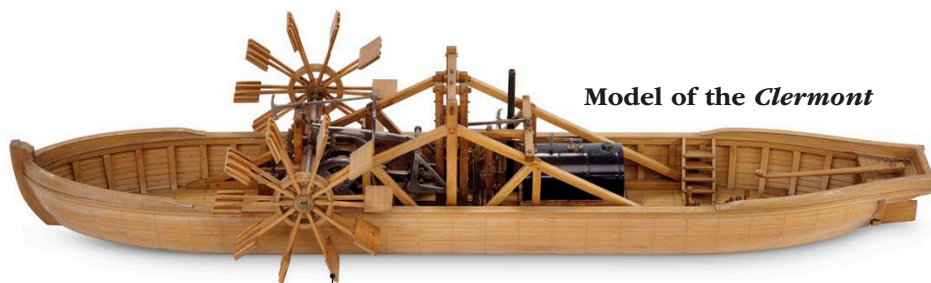
- Taken out of service in 2009, the oil tanker *Seawise Giant* was the longest ship ever built at 1,504 ft (458.4 m) long—longer than the height of the Empire State Building.
- There are more than 50,000 ships around the world: 31 percent cargo ships, 27 percent tankers, 15 percent bulk carriers, 13 percent passenger liners, 9 percent container ships, and 5 percent other vessels.

First commercial passenger steamer

- **What?** *Clermont*
- **Who?** Robert Fulton
- **Where and when?** US, 1807

Although the first working steamboat was the French *Pyroscaphe* of 1783, the first steamer to carry passengers

regularly was the *Clermont*. It was built by the American engineer Robert Fulton in 1807, and carried people up and down the Hudson River from New York City to Albany.



Model of the *Clermont*

Paddle wheels
on each side

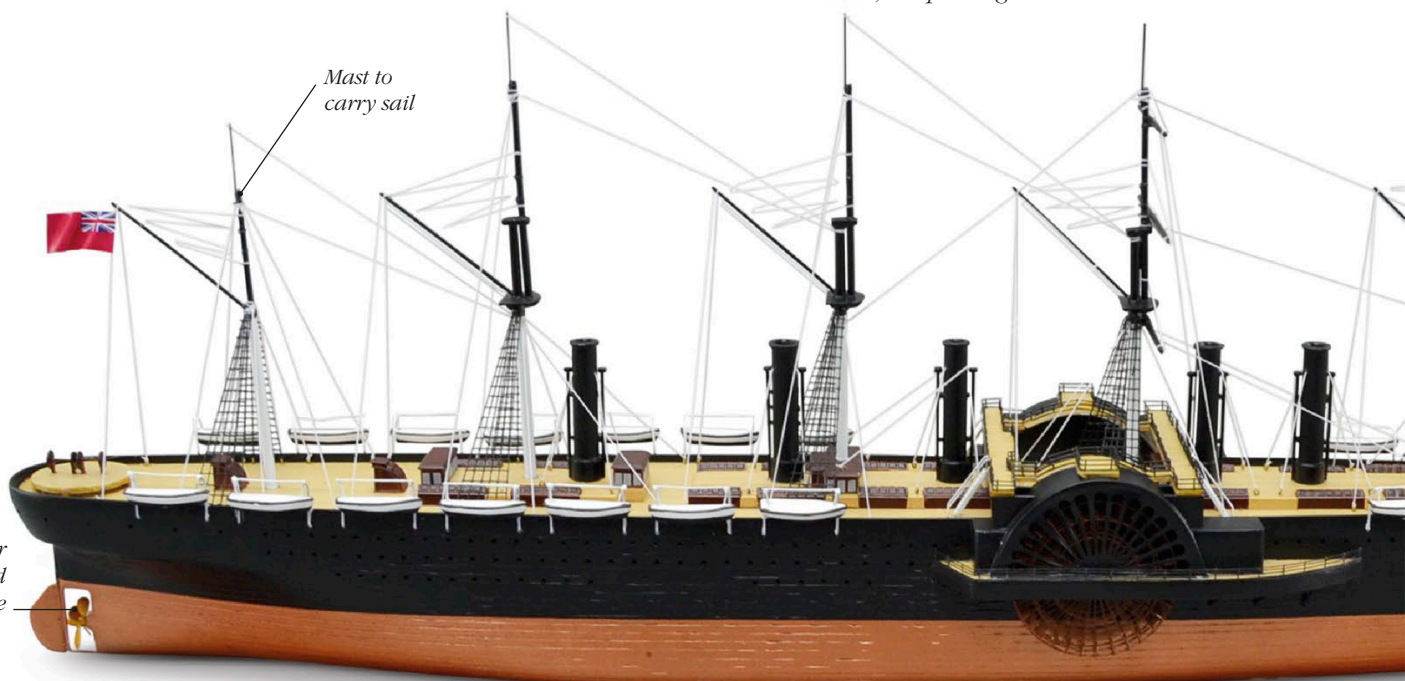
Round-the-world steamship

- **What?** *SS Great Eastern*
- **Who?** Isambard Kingdom Brunel
- **Where and when?** UK, 1857

After his success with *SS Great Britain*, Isambard Kingdom Brunel wanted to build a massive steamship that could carry enough fuel to sail around the world. His answer was the *SS Great Eastern*. At 692 ft (211 m) long, it was six times bigger than any ship previously built. Although it made many crossings of the Atlantic Ocean, it never sailed around the world and was not a commercial success.

▼ SS GREAT EASTERN

The ship's size allowed it to carry 4,000 passengers at a time.



Mast to
carry sail

Propeller
powered
by engine